parents don't support their dream," he says. "The tournament will help change the mentality."

Over the past few years, Kho Kho has become more spectator-friendly. The number of players is now down from nine to seven and a *wazir*, a defender who can chase from both directions, has been introduced. It's evident in the Ultimate Kho Kho League where, much like kabaddi, the game is played on the mat. "We have improvised the rules to reflect the game's speed and agility and make it exciting," says Mittal. A third edition of the league is planned for later this year, this time including international players. "We will surpass the Pro Kabaddi League," says Mittal. "Kho Kho is played in 55 countries, and by the end of the year we will be in 90. We have a global presence." The ultimate aim, he adds, is to have Kho Kho at the 2030 Asian Games and as a demo game at the 2032 L.A. Olympics, nearly a century after its unofficial debut at the Berlin Games.

Meanwhile, as Shaikh prepares at the national camp in Delhi, younger sister, Afreen, who is also a professional KhoKho player, will keenly follow the action. Says Shaikh, "From being a lone soldier, there's a lot of *oorja* [energy] now around the sport. We now have a platform to show our skills, which we didn't earlier." ■

–Suhani Singh

SPORTS

BREAKING BARRIERS

The Women's Hockey India League is a shot in the arm for the sport, feels ace player Udita Duhan

At one point, Udita Duhan was overwhelmed by the suspense around her bid during the Women's Hockey India League (WHIL) auction. She hit mute on the live stream and tried to distract herself. But in the next few minutes, the teammates seated by her side roared with delight. Duhan had been signed by Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers for Rs 32 lakh, making her the most expensive player in the league. "There was so much excitement that I figured it was big. At the same time, it means I have to prove myself, be consistent," says the 27-year-old.



UDITA DUHAN was signed for Rs 32 lakh by the Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers, making her the most expensive player in the WHIL

ADIMAZES/HOCKEYINDIA

The inaugural edition of WHIL that got under way on Jan. 12 is a relatively short affair of two weeks featuring just four teams. In contrast, the ongoing men's HIL has eight teams and runs over a month. But it's the first opportunity for players like Duhan to be part of a league and rub shoulders with top internationals, this time as teammates rather than opponents.

"At tournaments, we don't get a chance to interact with other players. Over the past few days, we've been trying to understand their mindset, watch their training schedules," Duhan says.

The core of the Indian national team will feature in the league, its timing just right to ready them for the FIH Pro Hockey League in February. They'll be looking to make amends after finishing eighth in the tournament last year, besides failing to qualify for the Paris Olympics.

"A lot of negative thoughts crept in when we missed the Games. The team got together and thrashed it out. We had to move on from the debacle and start rebuilding. The gold at the Asian Champions Trophy in November was a big boost," she says.

Duhan has settled into the centreback position after Deep Grace Ekka's retirement last year. A striker during her younger days, the attacking instinct serves her well, making quick interceptions and surging up the field to create opportunities and even scoring once in a while. Bengal Tigers' Aussie coach, Glenn Turner, will be expecting more of the same from Duhan, who'll also be juggling responsibilities as captain and a penalty corner specialist.

"I was carefree as a junior but have learned how to carry the team over the past few years. I want to enjoy the HIL experience. As the league expands in the coming years, it will be a good platform for young players to show what they are made of and become contenders for the national team," she says. ■

–Shail Desai